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# The Cost of War for Burundi's Elite - Explaining Civil Conflict in Burundi

This paper examines possible causes of the Burundian Civil War and provides a policy prescription for mitigating its costs. One proposed explanation for the war is that mass poverty amongst Hutu men led to frustration with the oppressive Tutsi elite, and these Hutu men were corralled to violence by insurgents. A second argument attributes the war to a commitment problem in which both sides believed they needed to strike first for their own protection: Tutsi groups launching attacks to safeguard their ethnic minority, and Hutus to outpace Tutsi aggression. A third school of thought argues that Burundi's military elite could wage war without bearing its costs, compelling them to pursue violence rather than seek negotiation. This paper argues that the third school of thought is the most plausible explanation of conflict. Thus, in order to compel the Burundian military to negotiation, their low-stakes evasive strategy needed to be replaced with a more confrontational one. International pressure to integrate Hutus into the military would have limited the military influence of Burundi's Bururi elite and compelled them to take on a higher-stakes strategy.

## Literature Review

One explanation of the Burundian Civil War is that large scale poverty led Hutu men to join insurgent movements opposing the ruling class of Tutsi elite. The exclusionary policies put in place by the Burundian government resulted in extreme privilege for officials and their families, while immense social and economic inequality enveloped the rest of the country.[i] In 1985, Burundians were some of the world's poorest people, with a per capita income of 200

USD.[ii] The Tutsi elite had access to education and wealth.[iii] Tutsis had significantly more opportunity for social mobility than Hutus.[iv] Despite producing the least food per capita as a province, 39% of children from the Bururi province were enrolled in schools, while the rest of the country averaged 24.5%.[v] The Bururi province's average per capita income was 35% higher than the national average.[vi] The Bururi province had the most teachers per classroom in the country, and their illiteracy rate was 7% lower than the national average.[vii] This inequality created a breeding ground for frustration, and angry unemployed Hutu men were corralled to violence against the government. [viii]

The second school of thought describes a commitment problem, in which Hutus and Tutsis did not trust each other to abstain from violence, compelling both groups to strike. During Belgium's occupation of Burundi, colonial authorities implemented policies that fueled resentment and division between the Hutu and Tutsi[ix]. The dynamic pre-existing class system gradually became a rigid system marked by Tutsi dominance.[x] In 1966, army captain and Tutsi extremist Michel Micombero took control of the country, filling the government with officials of similar mind.[xi] Between 1965 and 1993, there were several violent confrontations between Hutus and the Tutsi regime, which led to massacres and the ethnic cleansing of Hutu intellectuals.[xii] Additionally, the 1959 Rwandan crisis created nightmarish vision for the Tutsis of Hutu rule.[xiii] Tutsi military officials believed that they needed to control the government to secure safety for their ethnic minority, so in 1993 the monoethnic Tutsi military mounted a coup against the newly elected Hutu government, successfully assassinating President Ndadaye.[xiv] Anticipating further aggression by the Tutsi military, the Hutus preemptively attacked.

The third explanation argues that the Tutsi elite from the Bururi province, who controlled the military, were unwilling to yield their political power and privilege, and could wage war

without bearing the brunt of its repercussions. Since Michel Micombero's rise to power in 1966, the Tutsi elite from the southern Bururi province controlled Burundi's political, economic and military systems.[xv] Their policies helped cement their power, while leaving the rest of the country, particularly the Hutu majority, in a state of poverty and exclusion.[xvi] President Ndadaye's election in 1993 gave a voice to the long-oppressed Hutu people, and also posed a direct threat to the Bururi elite's power.[xvii] The military assassinated the new president, and the Hutus decided that war was favorable to living under an oppressive regime. The military implemented on a strategy of warfare that endangered civilians, avoided direct combat with rebels, and kept the military's risk in the conflict to a minimum. Burundi's military elite could fight the war without bearing direct consequences, leaving violence a favorable path over negotiation.

Addressing Poverty Amongst Hutu Men

The first school of thought suggests that impoverished Hutu men fueled the insurgency. However, many poor Hutu men were recruited by the government to fight the insurgency. The Guardians of Peace were a government sponsored paramilitary organization comprised almost entirely of young impoverished Hutu men.[xviii] They stayed in military posts, supporting the military by cooking and fetching water for soldiers.[xix] They are credited for a decrease in rebel activity after conducting armed patrols of the Kabira forest.[xx] Guardians of Peace were also used to guard camps of displaced people in the Kanyanza province.[xxi] Additional groups were also established in the Kabarore, Murutta and Matongo communes.[xxii] After an FDD advance into southern Burundi in 1997, additional branches were established in the Rumonge, Buyengero, Burambi, Bururi, Makamba and Rutana provinces.[xxiii] After an FNL rebel attack near the capital

of Bujumbura in fall of 2000, the government brought hundreds of Guardians of Peace to reinforce troops.[xxiv] By 2001, 30,000 Burundians had been trained as Guardians of Peace, with 5000 protecting the Bururi province, home of Burundi's Tutsi elite.[xxv] The Guardians were commended for their work fighting rebels by high ranking military officers and President Buyoya.[xxvi] The government also utilized Hutu men in urban areas to conduct nightly organized patrols.[xxvii] In some parts of the country, all Hutu men were required to participate.[xxviii] However, those with money or political connections could escape service, leaving poor Hutu men as the primary forces of the program.[xxix] In mid 2000, local officials in Kinama and Buterere established urban versions of the Guardians of Peace, recruiting about 100 and 50 young unemployed Hutu men, respectively.[xxx] These men conducted armed patrols of their cities to protect from insurgents.[xxxi]

Rather than using unemployed Hutu men to fill their ranks, the rebellion often abused and extorted them. In the Kabezi commune, FNL insurgents murdered 4 Guardians of Peace and dumped their bodies on a public road as a warning against supporting the program.[xxxii] In the Bururi province, the FDD warned all Guardians that they would catch and kill them, and sometimes threated their families.[xxxiii] By 1999, 821,000 people, or 13% of Burundi's population, were displaced.[xxxiv] Many of these displaced people lived in regroupment camps, which were set up in 1996 under the pretext of providing protection for civilians from rebel attack.[xxxv] The vast majority of people in these camps were Hutu.[xxxvi] However, Hutu rebels used these camps for fundraising by taxing the already impoverished residents. In the Ngara and Kibondo camps in neighboring Tanzania, FDD and FNL rebels coerced refugees to pay the equivalent of 50 US cents per person.[xxxvii] In one Tanzanian camp, FDD sympathizers were operating a detention

center, in which they interrogated and used violence against refugees whom they suspected were spying for the Burundian government.[xxxviii]

Addressing The Commitment Problem

The commitment problem suggests that the Tutsis feared that the Hutu government might abuse their power over the Tutsi minority. However, the policies put forth by the newly elected Hutu government show signals of inclusion, rather an abuse of power. Tutsis might have had reason to worry if Ndadaye attempted to wipe the military clean Tutsi presence. However, President Ndadaye planned to reform the military to make it inclusive of all ethnicities and regions of Burundi.[xxxix] Ndadaye's cabinet was bipartisan and multiethnic.[xl] 14 members were Hutu, and 8 were Tutsi.[xli] This is a generous amount, considering Tutsis only made up 14% of Burundi's population.[xlii] UPRONA, the Tutsi party, still held 16 seats in the national assembly, while Frodebu, Ndadaye's party, held 65 seats.[xliii] Ndadaye instituted free press, and even allowed criticisms of himself and the Hutu dominated government.[xliv] Ndadaye also encouraged all refugees from previous civil conflicts, regardless of ethnicity and political affiliation, to resettle in Burundi.[xlv] He freed all political prisoners and political exiles, regardless of their leanings.[xlvi] The Tutsi soldiers who attempted to overthrow President Buyoya in March of 1992 to stop democratization were freed.[xlvii] Former President Bagaza, a Tutsi supremacist exiled to Libya in 1988, returned to the country.[xlviii]

This school of thought also proposes that Hutus were incentivized to strike out of a fear that they would be targeted by the Tutsi military. However, all military attacks on the Hutu public since the end of Belgian rule were in retribution for Hutu uprisings. The conflict of 1965 and the subsequent ethnic cleansing committed by the government was in response to a Hutu

uprising, calling for the state to appoint a Hutu prime minister.[xlix] In 1971, the government completed ethnic cleansing of Hutus from the military and civilian service after an alleged coup plot by the Hutu.[l] In 1988, the country experienced civil conflict in the northern provinces of Ngozi and Kirundo after local Hutu groups launched a rebellion over government officials.[li] The 1991 massacres of Hutus by the Tutsi army began as a Hutu rebellion.[lii] Seeing as all previous strikes against the government ended in severe retribution, the Hutu had a reason to fear striking first, not an incentive.

Hutus Viewed War as Favorable to Living in an Oppressive State

The military's disproportionate response to Hutu rebellion demonstrated that war would be a better alternative to living under an oppressive regime. After the Hutu rebellion of 1965, the government began the ethnic cleansing of the Hutu government and military elite.[liii] They killed 5,000 Hutu, destroying local Hutu civilian and military leadership.[liv] In 1972, after an alleged coup plot by the Hutu, the government significantly ramped up their efforts to put down Hutu dissent.[lv] President Micombero's Interior Minister Shabura ordered the general slaughter of all Hutu, causing a quasi-genocide of Hutu intellectuals.[lvi] Army teams combed towns and villages of all sizes, slaughtering any educated Hutus they found.[lvii] Approximately 200,000 Hutus were killed, and 300,000 Hutus became refugees.[lviii] In 1988, the response to the rebellion in the Ngozi and Kirundo provinces led to 15,000 Hutu and Tutsi deaths, and the displacement of approximately 50,000 Hutu people.[lix] The putting down of the 1991 Hutu rebellion resulted in the deaths of approximately 3,000 Hutus.[lx]

The assassination of President Ndadaye showed that the voice of the Hutu opposition could not be heard through politics, leaving violence as the next step. During the election of 1993,

97.3% of registered voters took part, and 64.75% of the votes went to Ndadaye.[lxi] On the night of October 20th, 1993, the military organized a coup to decapitate the government, successfully assassinating Melchior Ndadaye, president of the republic; Pontien Karibwami, vice president and speaker of the National Assembly; Gilles Bimazubute, deputy speaker of the National Assembly; Juvénal Ndayikeza, minister of lands and communal development; and Richard Ndikumwami, director of intelligence.[lxii] Hutus destroyed bridges, blocked roads, and weapons were distributed.[lxiii] In the weeks following the coup, between 50,000 to 100,000 people were killed in retribution for the president's death and in the army's response to said retribution.[lxiv]

Burundi's Military Elite Could Fight the War Without Bearing its Cost

The Burundian military recruited civilians to fight to limit their own stake in the war. During the war the military nearly doubled in size, from about 20,000 to 40,000 soldiers.[lxv] The training period was reduced from one year to three months, and recruitment was opened to women, students, and boys as young as 10 years old.[lxvi] Thousands of members of Tutsi youth gangs in Bujumbura and other cities were given weaponry and minimal supervision, and were dispatched into combat.[lxvii] In early 1997, the FDD advanced into the Bururi and Makamba provinces, even reaching the home commune of President Buyoya and other military elite.[lxviii] In response, the government launched a civilian self-defense program, conscripting civilians into paramilitary service.[lxix] Refusal to participate in nightly patrols resulted in beatings, fines, or short-term imprisonment.[lxx] If authorities suspected resistors of supporting the rebellion, they were subject to execution.[lxxi] Missing one night of patrols resulted in beatings or fines.[lxxii] The Guardians of Peace received approximately one month of military training, and were permitted to use firearms.[lxxiii] The Guardians were forced to join on threat of punishment or fines.[lxxiv]

Recruits ranged from ten year old children to married men with children.[lxxv] They were subject to unpaid service for indeterminate periods..[lxxvi]

Tutsi and Hutu civilians, rather than the military, bore the impacts of Hutu aggression. After the military's assassination of president Ndadaye, an estimated 50,000 Tutsis civilians were massacred by Hutus in the week following the coup.[lxxvii] 300,000 people, many of them Tutsi, were internally displaced.[lxxviii] Severe ethnic cleansing followed, with Tutsi and Hutu civilians killed each other.[lxxix] Hutu insurgent groups frequently targeted Tutsi civilians rather than the army because they were easier targets.[lxxx] Rebels would raid towns to get good to survive.[lxxxi] If residents did not give them food, they were killed.[lxxxii] The rebels also killed anyone who did not share their ideology.[lxxxiii] The rebels would also take young people to fill their forces.[lxxxiv] In 1998, FDD troops were attacking the Bujumbura Airport and the Gakumbu military camp.[lxxxv] In the process, they killed hundreds of civilians, and 7,000 civilians fled.[lxxxvi] Hutu aggression against civilians, in conjunction with abuses by the military, resulted in 16% of Burundians losing all their money and goods, 28% of people losing close relatives, 23% of people being displaced, and the deaths of 17% of the total population.[lxxxvii]

The military's regroupment of Hutus allowed them to limit insurgent activity without putting themselves in danger. Armed forces ordered over 300,000 people from the rural Hutu population into camps where they could be monitored and controlled by the military.[lxxxviii] The military forced them there through indiscriminate attacks.[lxxxix] They burned civilian homes, raped and beat them, and killed hundreds who refused to enter the camps.[xc] In some areas where camps were created, all civilian homes were destroyed.[xci] These camps were crowded and unsanitary, causing thousands to die from malnutrition and disease.[xcii] In certain camps, the soldiers forced

residents to work the fields and provide them with food.[xciii] The camps successfully curbed insurgent activity in some areas of northern Burundi.[xciv]

By targeting Hutu civilians, the military made Hutus fear being associated with insurgent activity without putting themselves into combat with rebels. Even when there was an opportunity for direct confrontation, the army rarely faced rebels head on.[xcv] Rather, the army targeted Hutus as a whole for retribution for insurgent activity.[xcvi] The military frequently killed and injured civilians in operations directed at insurgents.[xcvii] They also killed wealthy or educated Hutus that they believed might be a threat to the government.[xcviii] There were over 300,000 people killed in the war, mostly Hutu, and 700,000 Hutus were displaced.[xcix] When the FDD attacked military posts to kill soldiers, the government would respond by killing Hutu civilians.[c] The typical pattern of attack was that the rebels would raid a town and coerce the people into giving them food, and the army would come back later and attack the townspeople.[ci] Civilians feared that their supporting insurgents would cause them to be targeted by the government.[cii]

Policy Recommendation

The root of conflict lies in the fact that Burundi's military could fight the war without bearing its costs, causing them to choose conflict over negotiation. In order to mitigate this issue, policy must target the military, which allows the Bururi elite to conduct this low-stakes warfare. This section argues that international actors should have pressured the Burundian government to integrate Hutus into the military, disrupting the Bururi elite's ability to conduct low stakes warfare.

The Bururi elite used their complete control over the military to protect their interests for decades. Integrating Hutus into the miliary would disrupt their control over the direction of the

war. Since Michel Micombero's rise to power in 1966, the Burundian military became a monolithic Tutsi army, under control of the Bururi Tutsi elite.[ciii] The military was used to guarantee political power for these southern elite.[civ] The government instituted systematic discrimination against non-southern Tutsi, and had the military under their wing to challenge any opposition.[cv] In 1971, there were rumors of a possible re-establishment of the monarchy, and Prince Ndizeye was assassinated by the army.[cvi] In 1972, in an effort to consolidate power, the Southern Tutsi completed ethnic cleansing of Hutu from the military and civil service.[cvii] The army also used the opportunity to remove power from the Tutsi from the Muramvya province, and those other parts of the country.[cviii] The military assassinated President Ndadaye in 1993 since his presidency threatened the political and economic power of the Tutsi elite.[cix] Sharing military power with Hutus would disrupt the Bururi elite's sole control over the war's direction.

Hutu soldiers would be more likely to prefer direct combat with rebels, given the abuses rebels committed against Hutu civilians. The FDD attacked, executed, and massacred Hutu civilians.[cx] Insurgents often pillaged crops and property of Hutu civilians.[cxi] In some cases, insurgents forced civilians to live under areas of their control, and provide for then through farming and other forms of labor.[cxii] Insurgents also raped civilians and destroyed their property.[cxiii] Battles between rebel groups killed 600 civilians and displaced over 30,000 others.[cxiv] The FDD raided, pillaged, burned and stole from Hutu civilians in Makamba on a nightly basis.[cxv] Civilians from the Mabanda commune reportedly did not sleep in their own homes, fearing they will be killed in raids.[cxvi]

Hutu soldiers would oppose the human rights abuses committed by the army against Hutu civilians, incentivizing the army to attack the rebels more directly. In Bururi, rebels passed through a village to steal cows.[cxvii] The military responded by killing an overwhelming number

of civilians as retribution for the townspeople's cooperation with the rebels.[cxviii] In the town of Kabezi, the FDD attacked, killing 6 people.[cxix] The army responded by killing civilians, claiming the townspeople were supporting the FDD.[cxx] After the FDD killed the chief of the Magara Zone, the Hutu civilians were forced into a regroupment camp for a month as punishment.[cxxi] In the regroupment of residents from Muramvya, the military killed a large number of people, and many went to the forest to hide.[cxxii] These abuses would frustrate Hutu soldiers, and create tension within the military. Thus, the army would be incentivized to focus their attacks away from civilians and onto rebels.

Direct conflict with rebels would be more dangerous than killing unarmed civilians. The FDD was comprised of 10,000 armed combatants, and the FNL 2,000-3,000.[cxxiii] The FDD assassinated several civilians who they suspect as collaborators with the government.[cxxiv] The FDD also assassinated Hutu and Tutsi politicians in almost every Burundian province.[cxxv] Additionally, they killed and abused massive amounts of the civilian population.[cxxvi] The military understood that direct conflict with rebels was more dangerous than blindly killing civilians. When the FDD attacked Kiryama, soldiers took 40 minutes to get there, even though their post was only a few hundred meters away.[cxxvii] Soldiers took 5 hours to arrive to defend Buta, even though it was only ten minutes from them in Bururi.[cxxviii]

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